making enough money these days and brokers were advised to ignore them. Doctors were a problem because they never answered their phones, so it was deemed best to approach Mrs. Doctor with an embossed invitation to a seminar. Prudential-Bache brokers were also encouraged to start a "tickler file," with the dates that options expired, dividends were paid, retirement funds were due, and so on, as a guide to which people should be cold-called when.

You may have begun to wonder: *But what about the stock market?* So did I. During coffee breaks from the language labs, only a handful of recruits hung around the Quotron machines, where I spent hours pecking in ATSI for "Angstrom" and GS for "Gillette." Once, I was joined by David Beard of Portland, Maine, who told me he'd burned out on wheat futures before he joined Merrill Lynch. He said he was anxious to start working, so he could make up for his losses. I identified with him immediately.

How many stockbrokers, historically, come from the ranks of failed investors I wasn't sure, though I'd already heard one broker admit that brokers are losers in the stock market. From one of the history books, I'd learned that the earliest stockbrokers were found in Amsterdam in about 1600, but nothing was said about what drove them into this business. In *The Common Sense of Money and Investments,* written by the elder Rukeyser, I'd read that the word *broker* comes from the Saxon *broc,* which actually means "misfortune."

Stockbrokers had suffered a general bad reputation—as bumblers, connivers, or worse. In the rural towns and villages of the 1870s, the summer visit of the stockbroker caused many citizens to "close their shutters in alarm," according to Matthew Josephson in *The Money Lords*. During the 1920s, the same author wrote, "The typical stockbroker was well spoken and well clad in conservative style, but not oversupplied with brains." Recently, and perhaps thanks to the bull market, the broker's reputation had improved. In a Gallup poll on which professions deserved the public trust, stockbrokers came in 16th out of 30. They rated no worse than congressmen and building contractors, higher than used-car dealers, and far below priests.)

To imply that the Merrill Lynch trainees never had a practical lesson in their newly-chosen field, investments, would be wrong.